

HAPPENINGS IN A CEMETERY

* Blue denotes ppt slide

* Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Matthew 28:1-15 (KJV) *“In the end of the Sabbath, as it began to dawn toward the first day of the week, came Mary Magdalene and the other Mary to see the sepulchre. 2 And, behold, there was a great earthquake: for the angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat upon it. 3 His countenance was like lightning, and his raiment white as snow: 4 And for fear of him the keepers did shake, and became as dead men. 5 And the angel answered and said unto the women, Fear not ye: for I know that ye seek Jesus, which was crucified. 6 He is not here: for he is risen as he said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay. 7 And go quickly, and tell his*

disciples that he is risen from the dead; and, behold, he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall ye see him: lo, I have told you. 8 And they departed quickly from the sepulchre with fear and great joy; and did run to bring his disciples word. 9 And as they went to tell his disciples, behold, Jesus met them, saying, All hail. And they came and held him by the feet, and worshipped him. 10 Then said Jesus unto them, Be not afraid: go tell my brethren that they go into Galilee, and there shall they see me. 11 Now when they were going, behold, some of the watch came into the city, and shewed unto the chief priests all the things that were done. 12 And when they were assembled with the elders, and had taken counsel, they gave large money unto the soldiers. 13 Saying, Say ye, His disciples came by night, and stole him away while we slept. 14 And if this come to the governor's ears, we will persuade him, and secure you. 15 So they took the money, and

did as they were taught: and this saying is commonly reported among the Jews until this day.”

INTRO: The Scripture setting this morning is at the end of a horrific weekend that culminated in the death of the Son of God. Jesus was killed in the most despicable way a person could be murdered.

ILLUSTRATION: A woman wrote J. Vernon McGee and said: *"Our preacher said that on Easter, Jesus just swooned on the cross and that the disciples nursed him back to health. What do you think?"* McGee replied, *"Dear Sister, beat your preacher with a leather whip for thirty-nine heavy strokes. Nail him to a cross. Hang him in the sun for six hours. Run a spear through his heart. Embalm him. Put him in an airless tomb for three days. Then see what happens."* -- Robert Russell, "Resurrection Promises," Preaching Today, Tape 151.

Though we may not visit the empty tomb in this life, we can take a trip there through God's Word.

The tomb was literally located at the foot of the hill where Jesus was crucified.

Following the crucifixion, the body of Jesus was placed in a borrowed tomb belonging to a rich man by the name of Joseph of Arimithea.

The body of Jesus was buried late on Friday afternoon. Very early on Sunday morning, while it was still dark, a group of women left Bethany, which was about 2 miles from Jerusalem, and arrived at the tomb of the stricken savior just after sunrise. The sun had already risen before they reached the tomb.

When they arrived at the tomb, they discovered some very unusual things were happening. A cemetery is not a place where one would expect much excitement, but this was no ordinary day, and what happened in that cemetery was off the chain.

AN EARTHQUAKE HAPPENED...

Matthew 28:2 (KJV) “And behold, there was a great earthquake.”

Earthquakes are mentioned several times in the Bible in both the Old and New Testaments. There was an earthquake when Jesus was crucified and another one occurred in the cemetery when Jesus was raised from the dead. Earthquakes reveal several things:

- They reveal God’s power... (It takes some power to shake the earth)
- They reveal God’s presence... (The veil was ripped)

- They reveal God... (Mt. Sinai - 10 commandments)
- They reveal God's Judgment... Hebrews 12:25-28 (KJV) *“For if they escaped not who refused him that spake on earth, much more shall not we escape, if we turn away from him that speaketh from heaven: 26 Whose voice then shook the earth: but now he hath promised, saying, Yet once more I shake not the earth only, but also heaven. And this word, Yet once more, signifieth the removing of those things that are shaken, as of things that are made, that those things which cannot be shaken may remain.”*

DIVINE INTERVENTION HAPPENED...

Matthew 28:2 (KJV) *“Behold, there was a great earthquake: for the angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and*

rolled back the stone from the door, and sat upon it.”

Angels visited the cemetery and rolled the stone away from the tomb of Jesus. The Angel did not roll the stone away to let Jesus out, but to let the people on the outside witness the fact that he had risen. (Jesus walked through walls after His resurrection)

It is interesting to note that the angel was still sitting on the stone when the women arrived. Why would the angel linger in the cemetery, just sitting there on the stone?

- It was a symbol of comfort... (The women missed the resurrection but not the messenger)
- It was a symbol of defiance... (Death had been defeated and the Angel sat in defiance of the greatest enemy of humankind - Jesus abolished death)
- It was a symbol of victory... (The political system convicted Him – The

crowd sentenced Him – The soldiers
killed Him – The presence of an Angel
sitting on a stone in front of an empty
tomb said everything)

THE WORLD’S GREATEST DECLARATION HAPPENED...

Matthew 28:5-6 (KJV) *“The angel
answered and said unto the women, Fear
not ye: for I know that ye seek Jesus, which
was crucified. 6 He is not here: for he is
risen, as he said. Come, see the place where
the Lord lay.”*

It is very humorous to me that the Angel
said to the women who had just witnessed a
resurrection, *“Fear not...”* Seriously? You
think?

As we take a closer look, we see that there
were four declarations in the cemetery:

- The angel declared the whereabouts of Jesus... Matthew 28:6 (KJV) *“He is not here....”*
- The Angel declared His resurrection... Matthew 28:6 (KJV) *“He is risen, as he said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay.”*
- The Angel declared His delegation... Matthew 28:7 (KJV) *“Go quickly, and tell his disciples that he is risen from the dead...”*
- The Angel declared His visitation... Matthew 28:7 (KJV) *“Behold, he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall ye see him...”*

CONCLUSION:

So what does all this mean to us?

A true story is told about a distinguished man, the only white person buried in a Georgia cemetery reserved exclusively for blacks. He had lost his mother when he was

just a baby. His father, who never married again, hired a black woman named Mandy to help raise his son. She was a Christian and she took her task seriously. Seldom has a motherless boy received such warmhearted attention. One of his earliest memories was of Mandy bending tenderly over him in his upstairs bedroom each day and softly saying, *"Wake up my boy, God's mornin' is come."*

As the years passed, this devoted woman continued to serve as his surrogate mother. The young man went away to college, but when he would come home on holidays and in the summer she would still climb the stairs and call him saying, *Wake up my boy, God's mornin' has come."*

One day after he had become a successful statesman, the sad message came: *"Mandy is dead. Can you attend her funeral?"*

As he stood by her grave in the cemetery, he turned to his friends and said, *"If I die before Jesus comes, I want to be buried here beside Mandy. I like to think that on Resurrection Day she'll speak to me again and say, 'Wake up, my boy, God's mornin' is come!'"* -- James S. Hewett, Illustrations Unlimited (Wheaton: Tyndale House Publishers, Inc, 1988) pp. 163-164.

Because He was raised, we are going to be raised. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 (KJV) ***"But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. 14 For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. 15 For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive and remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep. 16 For the Lord himself shall***

descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: 17 Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. 18 Wherefore comfort one another with these words.”

I Corinthians 15:51-57 (KJV) “Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, 52 In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. 53 For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. 54 So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written, Death is

swallowed up in victory. 55 O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory? 56 The sting of death is sin; and the strength of sin is the law. 57 But thanks be to God, which giveth us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

PLACES PREACHED:

CT Church Houston TX 4/20/14 (Easter)